

flower forms also lend themselves to certain garden styles. Tulips with sculptural cupped flowers planted *en masse* and the sharp flower shapes of many dahlias are ideal for formal schemes, while the looser flower forms of nectaroscordums and turkscap lilies, and arching spikes of crocosmias, create an informal look. Turf spangled with crocuses or snake's-head fritillaries (*Fritillaria meleagris*) mimics their wild habitat and provides early color in naturalistic schemes.

Bulbs add seasonal color and interest to mixed borders with annuals, shrubs, and perennials. Daffodils (*Narcissus*), crown imperials (*Fritillaria imperialis*), alliums, and dahlias all blend well with other types of planting. Unscented lilies make good partners for scented roses, while exotic-looking cannas and alstroemerias add spice to a tropical design. If you can't squeeze bulbs into your border, many are perfectly at home in containers and baskets.

Year-round interest

Choose carefully, and you can have a bulb in flower for most of the year. The first to appear in late winter are the snowdrops (*Galanthus*) and winter aconites (*Eranthis*), while early narcissus, muscari, crocuses, scillas, chionodoxas, dwarf iris, and *Anemone blanda* mark the onset of spring.

In mid-spring, fill your garden with vibrant yellow daffodils and bright tulips, or opt for the same plants in pastel shades—the choice is vast for both genera.

LAYERING BULBS IN CONTAINERS

Pots brimming with spring bulbs lift the spirits after a long winter, but you need to plan ahead to create the most spectacular displays. In fall, look out for bulbs at garden centers or in mail-order catalogs, and check flowering times for a synchronized display of tulips, daffodils, and grape hyacinths (*Muscari*).

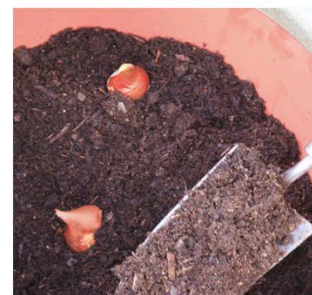


A multicolored display



1 Plant in layers

In fall, place crocks at the bottom of a large pot and add a 2in (5cm) layer of gravel. Then add a layer of good quality compost. Place the largest bulbs, for example daffodils, on the surface and cover with more compost so that the tips are just visible.



2 Cover the bulbs

Now place the next layer of bulbs, such as tulips, between the daffodil bulbs, and cover with more potting compost. Finally, add small bulbs, like grape hyacinths, on this top layer, and cover with compost. Press down lightly with your hands, and leave the pot in a sheltered, sunny spot.

Summer-flowering bulbs, such as *Galtonia candicans*, most alliums, the Peruvian daffodil (*Hymenocallis naricissiflora*), and ornithogalums offer colorful highlights.

These are followed in late summer by gladioli, crinums, dahlias, and crocosmias, which may continue to bloom into the fall until the frosts arrive. When the summer

spectacle is over, select fall-flowering nerines, crocuses, colchicums, and cyclamen, and to end the year's display, use *Cyclamen hederifolium*, whose marbled foliage often persists into winter.

For scented bulbs, choose hyacinths, bluebells, and scented daffodils for spring, and lilies and crinums for summer displays.

NATURALIZING BULBS

You can create spectacular effects by naturalizing bulbs in a lawn or under trees. Choose robust plants, such as snowdrops, daffodils, and crocuses, which are able to compete with trees roots and grass. To achieve a natural, random effect, toss the bulbs in the air and plant them individually where they fall. For each bulb, dig out a small plug of soil and turf, two to three times the depth of the bulb. After flowering, when the leaves have died, mow the grass.



BULB PLANTING PLANNER

Type of bulb	Planting time	Planting depth	Preferred conditions
Agapanthus	spring	4in (10cm)	Full sun in moist, but well drained soil
Allium	fall	2–6in (5–15cm)	Full sun in moist, but well drained soil
Colchicum	late summer	4in (10cm)	Full sun in well-drained soil
Crocus (spring) Crocus (fall)	fall late summer	3in (8cm) 3in (8cm)	Full sun in well-drained soil Full sun in well-drained soil
Cyclamen	fall	4in (10cm)	Partial shade in well-drained soil
Galanthus	early fall	1–2in (2.5–5cm)	Full sun or partial shade in moist soil that does not dry out in summer
Hyacinthus	fall	4in (10cm)	Full sun or partial shade in moist, well-drained soil
Lilium	fall	4–6in (10–15cm)	Full sun or partial shade; most prefer acid to neutral, well-drained soil
Muscari	fall	2in (5cm)	Full sun in well-drained soil
Narcissus	fall	4–6in (10–15cm)	Sun or partial shade in any reasonable, well-drained garden soil
Tulipa	late fall	3–6in (8–15cm)	Full sun in well-drained soil